before he was able to establish unchallenged control over Kabul. He wandered, dishevelled and thirsting, through the deserts of Sindh and Rajasthan, treading diplomatic water in the realm of Iran, threatening retirement yet fighting battle after battle to remain a force in the world.

A full account of Humayun's adventures would arouse all the pity and terror of Greek tragedy, and empty the ink from any storyteller's pen; it is a shame it isn't more often told. There is one occurrence from these times, however, that makes its way into every history of the early Mughals: it was now that Humayun met the girl of his dreams.

As the man in green had foretold, Hamida Banu was a descendant of Shaikh Ahmad of Jam, a renowned Persian saint of the twelfth century. She was also under fifteen years old and untouched by any desire to marry Humayun. For him, on the other hand, it was love at first sight.

They met in the camp of Humayun's youngest brother, Hindal, the gallant prince who had discouraged the despondent emperor from putting his harem to the sword after the rout in Kannauj. Ever since their escape from Lahore, the two brothers and their cousin Yadgar Nasir had been meandering through Sindh, neither in alliance nor at war – a 'blundering band',[30] as Haider puts it – scraping what living they could for their diminished armies. Humayun, for example, was camped by the Indus, trying to interest Mirza Shah Husain, the ruler of Sindh, in an attack on Gujarat, while also besieging one of his fortresses. As the siege dragged on and Shah Husain sent no clear reply, Humayun's soldiers were reduced to eating their own camels and horses.

It was at this point that Humayun decided to visit Hindal, who had camped a little downstream, in Patr (now Paat). Abul Fazl would like us to believe that Humayun had 'appointed' him there some months ago, but Gulbadan is more forthright. She says that Hindal had recently moved his camp across the river and the rumour was that he was planning to leave for Qandahar. That city, like Kabul, was ruled by Kamran, who also commanded the loyalty of his brother Askari. To have Hindal join that alliance would be another blow to Humayun's shattered fortune. He went hurrying to Patr, writes Gulbadan, to meet Hindal's mother, Dildar Begum, in the hope, presumably, that she would influence the prince in Humayun's favour.

When Humayun reached Hindal's camp, all the women of the harem came